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SPORT -O- GRAPHS

By George Barton

REGULAR patrons at Metropolitan stadium have cottoned in a large way to the stellar defensive play of the Millers' infield when shortstop Jose Valdivielso is teamed with Pumpsie Green at second base, Harry Malmberg at third base and Paul Smith at first base.

Over the years, Minneapolis team always have been blessed with topnotch infield combinations. These old eyes have gazed upon numerous classy Miller inner defenses during the years we reported baseball actively at Nicollet park from 1904 through 1946, inclusively.

During our first season at that historic old baseball enclosure, we were thrilled by the fine defensive play of the Miller infield made up of Jerry (Buck) Freeman, first base; Billy Fox, second base; Andy Oyler, shortstop and big Ed (Battleship) Gremminger, third base.

Everthing considered—offense, defense, know-how and competitive spirit, my all-time Miller infield would have to be the mighty quartet that contributed immeasurably to Minneapolis winning three pennants in a row in 1910-11-12. This infield had Warren (Doc) Gill, first base; Jimmy Williams, second base; Dave Altizer, shortstop; Hobe Ferris, third base. These four men could do everything a little better than any other set of infielders since their time.

Lacking the batting power of Gill, Williams, Altizer and Ferris, but on a par with them defensively was the stellar quartet which performed yeoman service in the winning of a pennant for Minneapolis in 1915. This infield was composed of Chick Autry, first base; Harry Holland, second base; Morley Jennings, shortstop; Wally Smith, third base.

There Were Others

MIKE KELLY presented a brilliant array of infielders in 1928 with Leo Cotter, first base; Jackie Hays, second base; Grant Gillis, shortstop and Sammy Bohne and Elmer Yoter, third base.

Rating next in all-around ability was the infield combination of 1932 which acquitted itself brilliantly in bringing Minneapolis a pennant after a lapse of 17 years. This aggregation had Joe Hauser, first base; Andy Cohen, second base; Ernie Smith, shortstop; Babe Ganzel, third base.

We admired in the ultimate, too, the Miller infield on the team of 1939 that finished a close second to the Kansas City Blues who happened to be one of the greatest teams ever to grace an American Association field. The Miller infield that year had Phil Weintraub at first base; Lin Storti, second base; Jimmy Pofahl, shortstop; Buck Fausett, third base.

Big League Caliber

OF MORE recent years, we regard the infield unit of the pennant-winning Millers of 1955 as the best since that 1939 quartet.

The classy array of 1955 had Gail Harris and Don Bollweg at first base; Wayne Terwilliger and Bill Gardner second base; Eddie Bressoud, shortstop; Rance Pless, third base.

Rating as close as an eyelash to the foregoing combination was the 1957 Miller infield of Orlando Cepeda, first base; Terwilliger, second base; Bressoud, shortstop and Jim Davenport third base.

Baseball men regarded the foregoing combinations as being of major league caliber defensively.

Class Galore Here

WHILE DWELLING on topnotch infield combinations, it is only fair to pay tribute to another duo of inner defense quartets on other American Association clubs of yesteryear.

We are referring to St. Paul's brilliant infield of 1919 composed of Johnny Neun, first base; Marty Berghammer, second base; Danny Boone, shortstop; Charley Dressen, third base.

Also, that great Kansas City quartet with Johnny Sturm, first base; Gerry Priddy, second base; Phil Rizzuto, shortstop; Billy Hitchcock, third base.

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